



MONTHLY UPDATE

Gabon: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-29 · 51 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

The month's largest event was the entry into service of the Nkok data centre on 3 July 2026, and its largest set of commitments was the open-innovation programme launched on 14 July with two accords attached. A satellite seminar closed on 27 July with eleven recommendations, the unified social register produced its first deliverable on 29 July, and the regional QR-code payment standard entered force on 29 July with the Gabonese scheme as its pilot.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The same 27 July Libreville seminar on space communications called for an autonomous national satellite system and sub-regional agreement for it to operate ([close of the seminar](#)).

Legislation and regulation

On 11 July nine civil-society organisations declared the broadcasting authority's social-media suspension unconstitutional, disproportionate and beyond its statutory remit, and demanded its abrogation; they also stated that a bill regulating social media exists and awaits promulgation ([declaration](#)). On 17 July the presidential spokesman defended the measure as temporary and conservatory and gave no lifting date. On 25 July an advocacy association presented a report built from two months of consultations, finding no transparent mechanism governing restriction of social networks and recommending revision of the ordinance of 8 April 2026 and greater independence for the broadcasting authority ([report](#)). On 13 August the national human-rights and democracy council took the opposite side of the same argument, [calling for judicial action against online outrage of the presidency and urging a CEMAC or continental legal framework for cyberspace modelled on the European Union's Digital Services Act](#).

On 23 July a national workshop validated by consensus five implementing texts on the digitalisation of teaching — two decrees, two orders and a decree creating a basic computing certificate — and forwarded them to the competent authorities with recommendations. They are technically validated and not adopted ([close of the workshop](#)).

The month's other legislative movement is procedural rather than expressive. A justice ministry commission [submitted a draft Code of Civil Procedure on 11 August](#), a rewrite of the 1977 ordinance running to more than 800 pages that would let procedural filings be made and held electronically, introduce secure digital tools, and harmonise with the OHADA uniform acts. Professional consultation and parliamentary debate are still ahead, and the draft text is not held.

An earlier instrument reached the base this month and it is the furthest-going measure of its kind reported in the region. An ordinance of February 2026 [fixes digital majority at 16 and obliges platforms to limit certain publication and interaction functions, to disable contacts from unidentified users by default and to provide age-verification mechanisms](#) — a duty on how a platform is built rather than a minimum age alone, where Rwanda is still preparing a restriction on under-16s and Zimbabwe has gone the policy route. The ordinance text is not held, only a comparative account of it, and no implementing regulation, supervisory body or enforcement action is on record.

The primary text of the social-media ordinance arrived, and it settles a conflation the base had carried. [Ordonnance n 0011/PR/2026](#), signed on 26 February 2026 and published in Journal Officiel n 110 of 8 April 2026, is the instrument the base had recorded twice — once as an ordinance whose text was not held and once as a bill reported second-hand to be awaiting promulgation. It runs to fifty-five articles in eleven chapters: digital majority is fixed at sixteen and account creation below it barred; editors must block publication, sharing and social-interaction functions for accounts identified as under-sixteen without recorded parental consent, disable by default any function letting unidentified persons contact a minor, filter algorithmic recommendation of violent, sexual or psychologically harmful AI content to minor accounts, and report quarterly to the competent authority; age-verification systems sit under a Haute Autorite de la Communication reference framework and a technical audit; and the referee numerique caps any temporary suspension of access to a platform at seventy-two hours. The twelve-month compliance clock runs from publication, to 8 April 2027.

Gabon also [brought non-resident digital platforms within Value Added Tax and the Contribution Speciale de Solidarite](#) through its 2026 supplementary finance law, reaching foreign streaming and platform services. No registration threshold, collection mechanism or first receipt is on file.

Regional collaboration

On 31 July the ministry's final technical committee of the administrative year named its next-cycle workstreams, among them a candidacy for International Telecommunication Union governance bodies, with no body, seat or election date named ([review](#)).

Standards

Service quality is the one obligation the base cannot show being enforced. Reporting of 25 August 2026 states that at a departmental capital, a commune since 1996 with a prefecture, town hall and schools, [the incumbent sells data bundles on a network whose coverage appears and disappears while prepaid credit and bundle validity run down normally, and puts the regulator's inaction to the president of its regulatory council](#). No quality-of-service determination, decision or sanction is published, which is why the row stands here as *Not held*.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The suspension of social media has now run [about five months, the Presidency calling it temporary and conservatory](#), with no lifting date given. [Nine civil-society organisations call it unconstitutional and beyond the authority's remit and demand abrogation](#). The decision's text is not held; its February start is inferred from a five-month count and, independently, from an operator's half-year filing, so the date carries month precision only.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

On 14 July, alongside the open-innovation programme's launch, the state guarantee company signed a credit-guarantee accord to put in place guarantee mechanisms reducing the risk borne by institutions lending to innovative young firms ([account of both accords](#)) – the first instrument in the base addressed to the cost of capital for Gabonese digital firms. Its terms were not published: no ceiling, coverage ratio, eligibility test, cost or duration, and it carries no envelope.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

On 27 July the Libreville seminar on space communications closed with eleven recommendations, confirming a hybrid fibre and satellite model on [2,000 km of fibre already deployed](#).

The national internet exchange point opened a reboot workshop at Libreville on 3 August, running to 8 August, with the Internet Society and AFRINIC as technical partners ([opening](#)). It [closed on 8 August with certificates presented after six days of peering, security and sovereignty training](#); AFRINIC called for a network of trained ambassadors to carry the skills into firms and administrations, and operator representatives named broader institutional buy-in as the task that remains. No participant number and no post-relaunch member count has been published.

Data Storage

The Nkok facility was inaugurated on 3 July 2026 with 92 racks over 3,000 square metres, 1 MW installed and a cost of XAF 8bn, peered to the ACE and SAT-3/WACS submarine systems ([figures given at the inauguration](#)). The operator stated at the same event that [about 95 per cent of data produced in Gabon was hosted outside the country](#).

On 31 July the minister inspected the second Tier III facility, a neutral carrier hotel built by the state company ACE Gabon SA at 160 racks and over 1 MW, interconnected to the submarine systems, and confirmed commissioning between end-November and early December 2026; he described it as a public structure financed by the local banking sector ([site inspection](#)). No cost figure was given.

Energy

About 22 per cent of the Nkok facility's site energy comes from a photovoltaic plant, with water-free cooling ([figures given at the inauguration](#)).

Cybersecurity

The utility [restored billing and payment in Libreville and seven interior centres after the attack that took down 95% of its systems](#), describing its network on 4 August as healthy, secured and protected by reinforced measures, with restoration continuing elsewhere. The account is the company's own, the attackers are described as unidentified, and no forensic, criminal or damage-cost report is on file.

An audit that was signed in May reported in August. The state digital agency [delivered its information-systems audit findings to the health insurance fund on 12 August](#), three months after the two signed the memorandum, naming human resources, data and infrastructure as the three pillars of the fund's technology roadmap. The findings themselves are not published, and no remediation plan, timetable or cost is stated.

DPI

Data Exchange

The regional interoperable QR-code standard was launched at Douala on 29 July 2026 under the monetary union regulation of 8 April 2026, in force across all six member states and settled through the regional switch, with the Gabonese scheme as its pilot ([launch](#)). The switch's 2025 figures, presented the following day, were 20.3m transactions worth FCFA 863bn across 153 participants ([figures](#)). On 9 July the central bank acceded to the pan-African payment and settlement system, with member-state banks to be connected by the end of 2026 ([announcement](#)).

A different kind of exchange went live in August. The airport-security committee [moved its advance passenger information and passenger-name-record system into its operational phase on 14 August](#), naming Royal Air Maroc lead carrier for IATA-code implementation under the state's convention with SECURIPORT, with border risk-screening the stated purpose. The convention terms, the retention rule for passenger data and any authorisation by the data-protection authority are not held — and the country's biometric-processing prohibition, with the defect already recorded in its derogation, sits alongside it unremarked.

Digital Payments and Fintech

[Domestic acceptance figures published on 30 July put banks at 457,377 cardholders among 673,793 clients, against 326 cash machines and 1,535 merchant terminals](#); of 1,101,434 transactions in June, 62.41 per cent were cash withdrawals and 24.61 per cent terminal payments ([bank association](#)).

Sectoral management information systems

On 30 July the education ministry received 1,000 tablets for what the minister described as 148 connected schools ([handover](#)).

The state's civil-service human-resources record has been failing for months. The Fichier unique de référence is [near-inoperative, blocking tenure confirmations, reclassifications, recruitments and promotions and stopping their pay effects reaching agents, the breakdown sitting in the data-replication link between the civil service and pay services](#); on 25 August the vice-president of the government ordered an emergency plan restoring career management, agent mobility and data replication. The civil service ministry says it is migrating to an integrated state human-resources management system.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

On 2 August the border agency's tourist electronic visa platform, developed in 2025, was presented to the travel trade ([account](#)). A second platform was shown rather than launched: administration.ga was [presented to the Vice-President as an integrated suite for secure messaging, meeting management and the exchange of confidential documents between civil servants, built with a Gabonese start-up, with the state holding the source code at no cost](#). No contract, cost, timetable or hosting arrangement is stated.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Libreville's mayor stated the city [already operates its own revenue-digitalisation system, developed with the Treasury, and that the national scheme will not replace it](#). The system is unnamed and undated, with no coverage or revenue figure — the only statement the base holds that a Gabonese municipality runs digital revenue collection of its own.

Technology

AI

An operator [launched a voice artificial-intelligence service reachable by dialling 333 from an ordinary feature phone](#), with no smartphone and no internet connection required. Delivering an AI service over the voice channel reaches the part of the population a data-only service does not; no user count, language coverage or tariff is published.

ICT Industry

A ride-hailing platform [began recruiting drivers at Libreville in partnership with a local transport operator, without announcing a launch date, the cities it will serve, its tariffs or its regulatory framework](#). It works as a pure intermediary with no fleet or drivers of its own, entering a market where one competitor has operated since 2021 and electric taxis were deployed in late 2025 under a state-backed project.

Innovation ecosystem

The open-innovation programme was launched on 14 July 2026 with the employers' federation, addressing a population the organisers put at 150 to 200 start-ups, with pre-selection on 24 July and a final on 4 August ([launch](#)). The final was postponed on 6 August after participating start-ups objected to how the edition was organised, and a [revised agenda published on 11 August](#) runs pitches to 24 August and moves the final to late September or early October. The same account gives the programme's first participation figures: 155 registered start-ups, 133 of which submitted against its 16 published challenges, and 66 shortlisted. The figures are the organisers' own and no laureate list or selection criteria has been published.

On 4 July, at the data-centre inauguration, the ministry and the facility's operator signed a memorandum giving ministry-supported start-ups professional hosting at preferential rates ([account](#)). No rate, eligibility list or take-up figure has been published.

The state digital incubator was not closed after all. It [has been placed under interim management, a deputy director general of the state holding that owns 30 per cent of its capital taking the post pending a new model, with a state takeover, conversion to a parapublic entity, absorption into the national innovation centre or supervision by the holding all under discussion](#); the digital economy ministry is to decide.

Capacity

Literacy

On 23 July the validated implementing texts included a draft decree creating a basic computing and internet certificate for education, with no syllabus, awarding body, cohort target or start date attached ([workshop close](#)).

Training and skills

Certification training is [under way for participants at Libreville's American Corner under a digital-skills programme run with United States embassies](#). No cohort size or completion date is published.

More than 130 young people have been [trained in cybersecurity, networks, artificial intelligence and programming since June 2026](#) under a programme with the United States. No curriculum, certification or placement outcome is published.

Inclusion

Access to services

On 29 July the social affairs ministry presented the first deliverable of the unified social register at Libreville, with World Bank representatives present, alongside a stated commitment to full digitalisation of non-contributory social protection under the 2026-2030 development plan ([presentation](#)). No beneficiary count, coverage figure or platform was given, and the state's own account uses three different names for the register in the same document.

Data

National statistics

On 21 July an interministerial committee fixed the terms of a second census of economically weak Gabonese, with preparation through July and August and fieldwork from September 2026, drawing on the population census and health-insurance records; its stated purpose is that the existing social file is not reliable enough to target protection ([terms](#)).

Open data

Gabon was assessed again as [not meeting the minimum fiscal transparency requirements in the 2026 review, published 11 August 2026 for the period to 31 December 2025, which presses governments to publish and regularly update information on state financial obligations including those of major state-owned enterprises](#). Of 139 governments and one entity reviewed, 73 met the requirements and 67 did not.

Geopolitics

China activities

One of two accords signed on 14 July on the margins of the open-innovation programme's launch was with an equipment supplier, to create smart rooms, deliver training in networks, cybersecurity, artificial intelligence and software development, and supply its certifying training kits ([account of both accords](#)); its terms were not published — no room count, trainee target, cost or duration.

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